

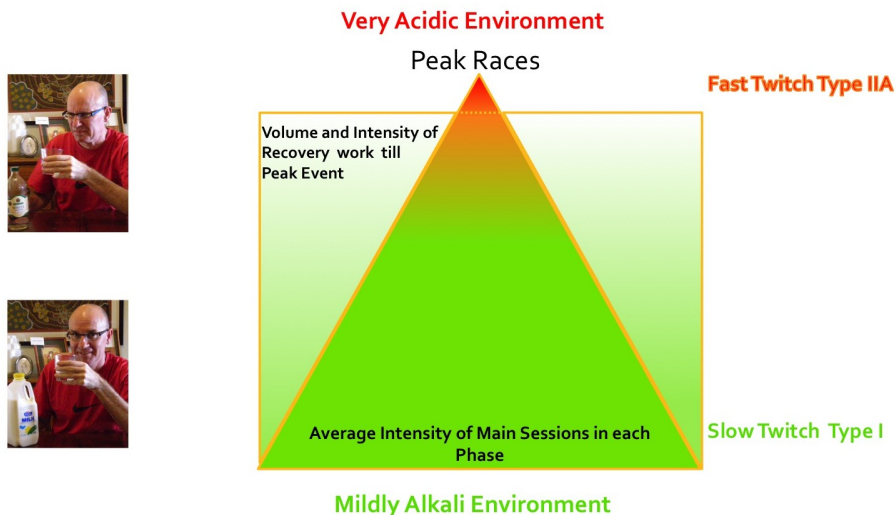
“So simple that no one can understand it” (Rich Englehart)

This diagram clearly shows the concept that is fundamental to the HITSYSTEM interpretation of Lydiard’s wonderful wholistic overview. It’s “so simple that no one can understand it”, according to Rich Englehart, a long-time acolyte of Arthur Lydiard and his philosophy.

In this diagram, I have attempted to show how simply I regard the whole philosophy, tied into the physiology. After thirty-plus years of studying the physiology of exercise, specifically for running, but applicable in theory to any sport, I now have put into a simple diagram, which I’ll explain afterwards so you’ll see how simple it all really is.

THE TWO GREAT SECRETS OF LYDIARD TRAINING

- 1 *The greater the Intensity of the main sessions in your phase of training, the more low-intensity recovery work is required.*
- 2 *Significant aerobic volume can still be done right until the peak*

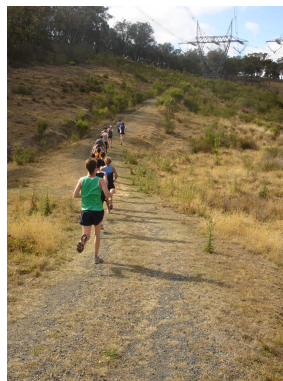


OK: the astute reader will note that milk itself is ever so slightly acidic, with a pH of 6.9, but compared to vinegar it is much more alkali. You get the point. The body’s energy, enzyme, and hormonal systems operate best in an oxygen-rich, mildly alkali environment of pH 7.365-7.40.

You'll notice that the type IIB explosive muscle fibers, are not included in the diagram. That's because healthy training towards a planned peak phase is a war between type I fibers and Type IIA fibers, aerobic metabolism and systemic acidosis. Total volume of training stays much the same as we move towards a Lydiard-based peak, however the intensity of most of it (recovery running) gets easier and easier as we move through the season towards the planned peak. The high-intensity IIA training volume gets smaller and smaller, but more and more intense, as we near a peak.

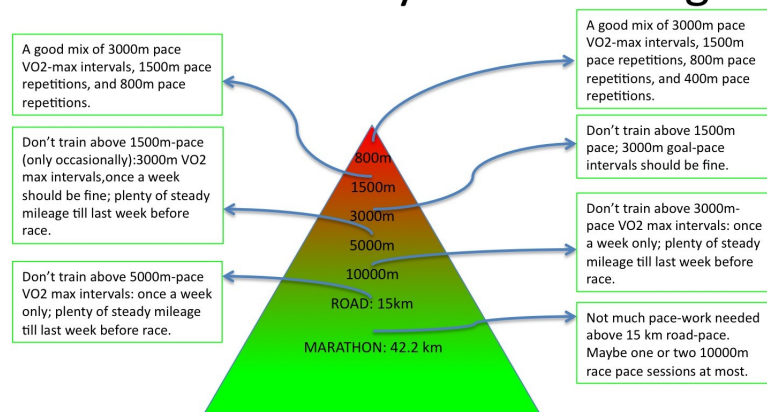
The type IIB fibers are still trained each week though, but if they're trained specifically and for no longer than 10 seconds each time, they won't affect the net balance of acid/alkali in training in any harmful way. Notice in the diagram that as we move through the phases towards the peak, more and more easy, restorative, aerobic type I muscle fiber activity is necessary to sandwich any very high intensity work.

For an absolute peak for middle-distance anaerobic glycolytic/lactic tolerance events like 800m, the extremely easy restorative work can drop away, steadily, without stopping abruptly, with the long easy runs dropping by 20% two weeks out, then another 20% one week out. So a 2-hour (120 minute) easy run on parkland or trails can become 1 hour 36 minutes, then 77 minutes one week out (OK-75 will do...but you get the idea...). The aerobic 'work' becomes almost pitifully slow and easy, in order to counter and recover properly from the high intensity work.



In summary: we only need to do our anaerobic work at or just above the speed of our target race. Any faster is a waste of time and effort. What WILL get you to the race result you desire is a MOUNTAIN of steady, enjoyable aerobic training, with the final topping being a few weeks of the anaerobic work we've been describing here. An aerobically fit runner is only weeks away from a top performance, and the anaerobic sessions will be 'easy'.

Hop Off the "Intensity Escalator" at or just above the level you're training for



These principles apply for the majority of sharpening work done coming into competition on the track or road. A tiny amount of higher intensity work will be of value only for final sharpening, for an experienced athlete and coach.

Remember that whenever you're training much above the anaerobic threshold, you're going into a competition between two muscle fibre types and their energy systems; too much training of one type will effectively 'de-train' the other. Any perceived inadequacies in pure SPEED and efficiency will be addressed by the fine neuro-motor coordination developed by leg-speed drills and fartlek run year-round.